

CHAO FA

THE TRAIL · THE COMPANION

EVERY CARD · THE ENDINGS · THE HISTORY

EVERY CARD, EXPLAINED

THE ENDINGS AND VOICES

LAOS, 1975–1980

This game is dedicated to all the men and women who served in the Vietnam War; to the Hmong who served and were killed; to those who died in the jungles of Laos and those who are still there; to the CIA, to General Vang Pao, and to everyone who brought attention to this tragic chapter of history.

SECOND EDITION · THE COMPANION · EVERY CARD, THE TWO ENDINGS, THE HISTORY AND THE VOICES (2026)

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What this book is for

Keep it beside the board. The first half lists every card in the game with what it does, where it is found and why. The second half is read at the end of the game: the two endings, the history behind them in date order and the voices of real people. What became of each villager is in the Endings booklet, one numbered ending for every fate; the chapter here tells you how to find the number. It is all based on the real-life stories of Hmong families, a countryless nation, who lived through these years; disputed figures say that they are disputed.

EVERY CARD

The map: what is found where

Every item in the game lives in one place, for a reason drawn from what refugees, soldiers and villagers really carried, hid and left behind. Each place's deck is listed in full, in no particular order (the deck is shuffled).



Village Ruins · Home · 19 cards

Your own village or a neighbour's, burned or abandoned when the soldiers came. Families left in a hurry. Silver, tools and keepsakes were buried under floors or left on the altar shelf.

Danger 2 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 0 · the hills of Xieng Khouang

CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
Soul Lock	Item	+2 DEF (best for Chai)
Book	Item	+2 DEF (best for Tou)
Doll	Item	+2 HP (best for Gao)
Hammer	Item	+2 ATK (best for Chong)
Ring	Item	+1 HP, +1 DEF (best for Blong)
Needles	Item	+1 ATK, +1 DEF (best for Bao)
Paj Ntaub	Item	+1 DEF, +1 HP (best for Bao)
Su-Kah	Item	+1 DEF (legendary)
French Silver Coins	Item	Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman.
Iron Rice Pot	Item	The holder finds 1 extra Food each time they Forage.
Village Flintlock	Item	A hunting gun: +2 ATK.
Wood Axe	Item	A tool and a weapon: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.
Rice left in a granary	Food	+2 Food.
Rice left in a granary	Food	+1 Food.
Soldiers searching the ruins	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
A standing house wall	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
Already picked over	Nothing	No effect.
A Letter from Nong Khai	Key · Guarded	A cousin who crossed last year wrote where the camp is and who helped him. It is in the headman's burned house, and soldiers are still searching the ruins. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.



Swidden Fields · The hills · 17 cards

Hillside fields of upland rice and corn, cleared by slash-and-burn. Field huts held farm tools and the animals that worked the slopes. Fall is harvest time.

Danger 3 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 2, Winter 1

CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
Hoe	Item	+1 ATK, +1 DEF (best for Mai)
Knife	Item	+1 DEF, +1 HP (best for Mai)
Slingshot	Item	+2 ATK (best for Chao)
Tub Luj	Item	+2 DEF (best for Chao)
Scythe	Item	+2 ATK (best for Pao)
Carrying Basket (Kwb)	Item	+2 DEF (best for Pao)
Water Buffalo	Item	+1 DEF (legendary)
Gourd Water Bottle	Item	Clean boiled water: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll.
Sack of Seed Rice	Item	Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)
Machete	Item	A tool and a weapon: +2 ATK.
Ripe corn and pumpkins	Food	+2 Food.
Ripe corn and pumpkins	Food	+1 Food.
A patrol burning the fields	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
Ginger and herbs from the garden	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
Burned	Nothing	No effect.
Smoke From the Fields	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
Talk of the Road South	Key · A Price	Farmers in the field huts know which paths the soldiers watch. The farmers will talk, but their own children are hungry. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Pine Ridge · The hills · 14 cards

High, cool pine forest along the ridgeline above the villages. Men hunted birds and deer here, and families hid in the high woods when the shelling began.

Danger 2 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 0

CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
Bow	Item	+2 ATK (best for Sheng)
Hmong Gun	Item	+3 ATK (best for Sheng)
Cane	Item	+2 DEF (best for Blong)

	Horse	Item	+1 HP (legendary)
	Crossbow (hneev)	Item	Hunting: the holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.
	Pine-Resin Torch	Item	When the holder Searches, look at 2 cards and keep 1 (put the other on the bottom).
	Hunting Spear	Item	Keeps danger at arm's length: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.
	Wild mushrooms and a bird	Food	+2 Food.
	Wild mushrooms and a bird	Food	+1 Food.
	A tiger on the ridge	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A hunter's shelter	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
	Nothing but pine needles	Nothing	No effect.
	A Hidden Path	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	Signal Fires	Key · Wait for Dark	Resistance fighters light fires on the ridges to mark the safe way down. The fires are lit only after dark, and the patrols watch the ridges too. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.



Long Tieng Airstrip · The hills · 12 cards

The long dirt runway of Long Tieng, the Hmong army's old headquarters, between the karst hills. The last planes left in May 1975 with thousands still waiting by the strip. The army holds it now, with the stores the planes could not carry.
Danger 4 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 0 · Lima Site 20A
Everyone knew this strip: the planes came every day, until the day they did not. Sam Thong, with its hospital, lies over the ridge.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Army Blanket	Item	The holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll.
	Transistor Radio	Item	Look at the next Season card at any time.
	Cargo Parachute	Item	A dry tent: the holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll.
	Steel Helmet	Item	Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF.
	Flak Vest	Item	Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF.
	A torn sack of air-dropped rice	Food	+2 Food.
	A torn sack of air-dropped rice	Food	+1 Food.
	Soldiers watching the strip	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

	A burned-out supply hut	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
	A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
	Bare red earth	Nothing	No effect.
	A Pilot's River Chart	Key · On the Fallen	An old air chart with the Mekong fords marked in pencil. It is in the pocket of a dead soldier by the burned huts. His patrol is close. Key encounter: Take it now, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. An evade card, Tou or Gao can still get you away. Or leave it.



Bamboo Forest · The jungle · 13 cards

Dense groves of giant bamboo in the valleys below the ridges. Bamboo was food, water pipe, shelter and raft. Shoots come up in the rainy season.

Danger 3 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 2, Fall 1, Winter 0

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Tsaaj Nplaim	Item	+2 HP (best for Ka)
	Bamboo Float Tubes	Item	The holder draws 2 better crossing the river.
	Bundle of Raft Poles	Item	Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.
	Snare Traps	Item	The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.
	Bamboo shoots	Food	+2 Food.
	Bamboo shoots	Food	+1 Food.
	A militia patrol on the path	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Clean bamboo water	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	Only old bamboo	Nothing	No effect.
	Soldiers waiting in the grove	Ambush	Easy fight now: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	A Tunnel Through the Bamboo	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	Blazes on the Bamboo	Key · Mined	Families who went before cut marks in the bamboo to show the path. The soldiers found the marks too, and mined the path. Key encounter: Take it now, then everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 to 4, 2 wounds (a Dog sniffs out the mines: only on a 1). Or leave it.
	A Raft-Maker's Word	Key · A Price	A man cutting bamboo says which stream carries rafts down to the Mekong. He has a family to feed and will not say for nothing. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle · The jungle · 17 cards

Tall rain forest on the sandstone hills between the mountains and the Mekong, with leeches and little light. Good for hiding and full of wild food and medicine plants, but soldiers sweep it for people in hiding.

Danger 5 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 2, Fall 2, Winter 0 · the forest toward the river



Families walking down from Phou Bia toward Paksane came through these hills. Good for hiding, and the soldiers know it.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Herbs	Item	+2 HP (best for Lee)
	Dog	Item	+1 HP (legendary)
	Rattan Rope	Item	The holder draws 1 better crossing the river (tied to the raft or the others).
	Dropped Rifle	Item	A strong weapon: +3 ATK.
	Rattan Shield	Item	Armor 1 and +1 DEF.
	Wild yams and fruit	Food	+2 Food.
	Wild yams and fruit	Food	+1 Food.
	A sweep through the jungle	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A sweep through the jungle	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A hidden hollow	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
	Healing leaves	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	A Guide	Clue	Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.
	Lost in the undergrowth	Nothing	No effect.
	An ambush in the undergrowth	Ambush	Medium fight now: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	Monsoon Rain	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	A Resistance Courier	Key · Guarded	A runner tells you where and when to meet the people who can help. He is pinned down in a gully by a patrol. Free him and he will talk. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Soldier Who Deserted	Key · A Price	He fought for the other side and knows where the patrols sleep. He wants silver, or a gun, before he trusts you. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Limestone Caves · The jungle · 19 cards

Caves in the karst towers, dry inside even in the monsoon. The resistance hid weapons, rice and medicine in caves. Families sheltered there from air attacks.

Danger 1 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 0, Summer 0, Fall 0, Winter 0 · the karst toward Vang Vieng

The villagers remember the cave at Tham Piu, where a whole village sheltering from the bombing was killed. They go in quietly.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Silver Bar	Item	+2 HP (best for Chai)
	Cloth Mask	Item	+1 HP, +1 DEF (best for Meng)

	Chu Neej	Item	+2 DEF (best for Meng)
	Hmong Knife	Item	+2 ATK (best for Cheng)
	Medicine Box	Item	+2 HP (best for Kong)
	Qeej	Item	+1 DEF, +1 HP (best for Ka)
	Incense Sticks	Item	+1 HP, +1 DEF (best for Pa)
	Old Carbine	Item	A strong weapon: +3 ATK.
	Army Poncho	Item	Dry in the monsoon: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll.
	Hidden Rice Cache	Item	Gain 4 Food when found. (Then discard it.)
	Rice hidden in a jar	Food	+2 Food.
	Rice hidden in a jar	Food	+1 Food.
	Soldiers search the caves	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A dry cave	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
	An aid-post first-aid kit	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	An empty cave	Nothing	No effect.
	A Back Way Out	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	Names on the Cave Wall	Key · Guarded	Families scratched their names and the way they went into the rock. Soldiers are camped in the mouth of the cave. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Shaman's Blessing	Key · A Price	A txiv neeb calls the spirits to guide the family across the water. The ceremony needs an offering: incense, paper money, a rooster, or rice. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Lao Farm Village · The lowlands · 23 cards

A lowland village of Lao rice farmers, on the way to the river. Some villagers would trade, hide or guide Hmong families; others would report them.

Danger 4 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 2, Winter 1

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Translator	Item	+2 HP (best for Tou)
	Bandages	Item	+1 HP, +1 DEF (best for Lee)
	Joss Paper	Item	+2 HP (best for Pa)
	Rooster	Item	+1 ATK (legendary)

	Lao Clothes	Item	Disguise: every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.
	Bag of Salt	Item	The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage (salted food lasts).
	Mosquito Net	Item	The holder draws 1 better at the Toll.
	Quinine Tablets	Item	The holder draws 2 better at the Toll.
	Padded Cotton Jacket	Item	Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. Warm: 1 better at the Toll.
	Sticky rice from a kind family	Food	+2 Food.
	Sticky rice from a kind family	Food	+1 Food.
	Someone reports you	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Someone reports you	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A village healer	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	A Guide	Clue	Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.
	A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
	Doors stay shut	Nothing	No effect.
	A trap at the well	Ambush	Medium fight now: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	A Friendly Warning	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	A Lao Friend's Promise	Key · A Price	A Lao farmer will hide you near the river on the night you cross. He is risking his family. He asks for silver, or rice. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
	Market Gossip	Key · Wait for Dark	At market they say which nights the river patrols change. You must wait by the market until dark to hear it, where anyone could see you. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
	The Headman's Pass	Key · Guarded	A stamped paper that lets a family walk the lowland roads. The stamp is kept at the militia post at the edge of the village. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Monk at the Temple	Key · Wait for Dark	A Lao monk tells travellers which villages along the river are kind to strangers. He will speak only after evening prayers, and the militia walks past the temple at dusk. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.

Hin Heup Bridge · The lowlands · 18 cards

The road to Vientiane and the bridge over the Nam Lik, with an army checkpoint at its end. In the first spring of the flight, soldiers fired on the Hmong families walking this road to Vientiane. The fastest way south and the most watched; soldiers left gear and rations behind.



Danger 8 (hard fight) · **Forage** Spring 0, Summer 0, Fall 0, Winter 0 · Route 13
Everyone has heard what happened on this bridge in May 1975. Nobody crosses it in daylight.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	M-16	Item	+3 ATK (best for Cheng)
	Scalpel	Item	+2 HP (best for Kong)
	Forged Travel Pass	Item	Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.
	Captured Rifle	Item	A strong weapon: +3 ATK.
	Army Rations	Item	Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)
	Army Body Armor	Item	Armor 2 and +1 DEF.
	A dropped sack of rice	Food	+3 Food.
	A dropped sack of rice	Food	+1 Food.
	The checkpoint guards	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	The checkpoint guards	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
	Too many soldiers	Nothing	No effect.
	Shots from the ditch	Ambush	Hard fight now: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	A Ditch by the Road	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	A Patrol Timetable	Key · Guarded	Overheard at the checkpoint: when the trucks come and go. To hear it you must get close to the checkpoint itself. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Guard Who Looks Away	Key · A Price	One guard will let a family pass for a little silver. Only for silver. If you will not pay, he calls the others. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
	A Burned-Out Truck	Key · Mined	In the cab of a burned army truck, papers with the river posts marked. The road shoulder around the truck is mined. Key encounter: Take it now, then everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 to 4, 2 wounds (a Dog sniffs out the mines: only on a 1). Or leave it.
	A Ride on a Logging Truck	Key · A Price	A driver will hide a family under the logs as far as the river road. He wants silver first. Without it he drives on, and he has seen your faces. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Nam Xan Valley · The lowlands · 15 cards

A rocky stream running down into the Nam Xan, the river that meets the Mekong at Paksane. Fish, crabs and water all year. Following water downhill leads to the river.

Danger 3 (easy fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 2, Fall 2, Winter 1 · down to Paksane

CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
Rocks	Item	+2 HP (best for Gao)
Sharpening Stone	Item	+1 ATK, +1 DEF (best for Chong)
Fishing Pole	Item	+1 ATK (legendary)
Cast Net	Item	The holder finds 2 extra Food when they Forage.
Clay Water Jar	Item	The holder draws 1 better at the Toll.
Fish and river crabs	Food	+2 Food.
Fish and river crabs	Food	+1 Food.
A patrol at the ford	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
An overhanging rock	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
Empty water	Nothing	No effect.
The Stream's Mouth	Key · Wait for Dark	Follow the water down and it meets the Mekong at a quiet bend. The bend can only be reached at night, when the fishermen have gone home. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
Footprints in the Mud	Key · On the Fallen	Other families came this way, and recently. The trail ends at a soldier dead in the reeds. In his pack is a list of the fords, and his unit is looking for him. Key encounter: Take it now, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. An evade card, Tou or Gao can still get you away. Or leave it.
A Smugglers' Path	Key · Guarded	Salt and opium traders use a path through the reeds that the army does not know. The traders guard their path, and they shoot first. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
A Buffalo Boy's Shortcut	Key · A Price	A boy herding buffalo knows a dry way through the paddies to the river. He wants rice for his family before he will show you. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Mekong Reeds · The river · 15 cards

Reeds and mud flats on the Lao bank between Vientiane and Paksane, with Thailand across the water. Most families crossed from quiet stretches like this, at night, by raft or swimming. Nong Khai and its camp lie across from Vientiane.

Danger 4 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 1 · the Lao bank, facing Thailand

CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES

	Truck Inner Tube	Item	The holder draws 3 better crossing the river.
	Driftwood Logs	Item	Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.
	Mussels and river weed	Food	+2 Food.
	Mussels and river weed	Food	+1 Food.
	A river patrol	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Rest by the water	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	Mud and reeds	Nothing	No effect.
	Rifles in the reeds	Ambush	Medium fight now: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	Fog on the River	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	Lights on the Thai Bank	Key · Wait for Dark	You can see the lamps of a Thai village. Now you know where to aim. The lamps can only be seen after dark, from the open bank. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
	A Hidden Landing	Key · Guarded	A gap in the reeds where rafts are put in at night. A river patrol has found it and waits there. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Boatman's Son	Key · A Price	A boy who helps his father ferry families knows which night they go. His father will want silver or baht for a place on the list. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Fishing Hamlet · The river · 14 cards

A few stilt houses of Lao fishermen with boats pulled up on the bank. Fishermen sometimes ferried refugees across for silver, and sometimes turned them in.

Danger 5 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 2, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 1

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Thai Baht Notes	Item	Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman.

	Bamboo Fish Trap	Item	The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.
	Dried fish	Food	+2 Food.
	Dried fish	Food	+1 Food.
	A fisherman turns you in	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A friendly family hides you	Shelter	Keep in hand: +2 DEF in the next fight.
	A Boatman	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, each silver item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht) buys one boat seat.
	A Boatman	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, each silver item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht) buys one boat seat.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	No one answers	Nothing	No effect.
	Under the Stilt Houses	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	The Fisherman's Signal	Key · A Price	Three flashes of a torch from the far bank mean it is safe. The fisherman wants paying for the signal. If you will not pay, he may go to the soldiers. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
	A Night With No Moon	Key · Wait for Dark	An old woman tells you when the next dark night will be. She tells you only after you have waited with her through the night. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
	A Patrol Book in the Nets	Key · On the Fallen	A patrolman drowned in the nets. His book has the boat times. His comrades are dragging the river for him. Key encounter: Take it now, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. An evade card, Tou or Gao can still get you away. Or leave it.



Tha Deua Ferry · The river · 12 cards

The old ferry landing below Vientiane, where the boats to Nong Khai crossed, now a guarded army post. Boats are close by, but soldiers watch the landing day and night.

Danger 9 (hard fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 1 · across from Nong Khai

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Dugout Canoe	Item	Two people may cross by boat without paying a boatman.
	Rice from an empty guardhouse	Food	+3 Food.
	Rice from an empty guardhouse	Food	+1 Food.
	The guard post	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.

	The guard post	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	A Safe Crossing Place	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, everyone draws 1 better.
	A Boatman	Clue	Keep it with this tile. When you cross from here, each silver item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht) buys one boat seat.
	Searchlights	Nothing	No effect.
	The Guard Change	Key · Guarded	For a few minutes after midnight, no one watches the landing. You must get past the outer guards to see it. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	The Ferryman's Hut	Key · Wait for Dark	An old ferryman who lost his boat knows every sandbar between here and Thailand. He comes back to his hut only at night, past the guard post. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
	A Boat Left Untied	Key · Mined	A small boat at the end of the old pier, if you can reach it. The path to the pier is mined and lit. Key encounter: Take it now, then everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 to 4, 2 wounds (a Dog sniffs out the mines: only on a 1). Or leave it.



Plain of Jars · The hills · 13 cards

Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs. Fast to cross and easy to see across. The ground was bombed more than any other in the war, and the small bombs are still in the grass.

Danger 3 (medium fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 0

The jars stood here before anyone's grandfather. The craters are newer.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Bomb Casing Pot	Item	+1 Food whenever the party forages.
	Drop Tarpaulin	Item	The Winter Toll is 1 better for everyone.
	Entrenching Tool	Item	+1 ATK, +1 DEF for anyone.
	Rice from an abandoned paddy	Food	+2 Food.
	Frogs from the craters	Food	+1 Food.
	A patrol on the open plain	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Militia at the jars	Danger	Easy fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Bomblets in the grass	Old bombs	Everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 or 2, an old bomb, 2 wounds. The Dog: only on a 1.
	A crater field	Old bombs	Everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 or 2, an old bomb, 2 wounds. The Dog: only on a 1.
	A crater to lie in	Shelter	Keep in hand: +1 DEF in the next fight.
	Only the jars	Nothing	No effect.

	Across the Plain by Night	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	The Road Watcher's Word	Key · A Price	An old man who watches the road knows which trucks carry soldiers. He wants rice for his word. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.



Phou Bia Slopes · The jungle · 14 cards

The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families. The Chao Fa held the mountain, and whole villages hid with them. From 1977 the army came for it with artillery, from posts like Muang Cha below the slopes.

Danger 3 (medium fight, from 1977 6, hard) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 1, Winter 0

The mountain the resistance is named for. Up here the Chao Fa may find you before the soldiers do.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Pahawh Primer	Item	+1 DEF for anyone.
	Field Dressing	Item	Counts as medicine for nursing. Turn it face down when used.
	Soldier's Map	Item	Searching: look at one card more and choose.
	A hidden camp's rice	Food	+2 Food.
	Mountain roots	Food	+1 Food.
	Soldiers climbing the mountain	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A patrol on the ridge path	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	The Chao Fa Take You In	The Chao Fa	A band of resistance fighters shares their fire and their rifles for a while. Your next 3 fights: the party has +3 ATK.
	A Guide	Clue	Keep this card. Every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better.
	A night in a Chao Fa camp	Remedy	Keep in hand: +2 HP in the next fight.
	Cold, and nothing to eat	Nothing	No effect.
	Cloud on the Mountain	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	The Fighters' Trail	Key · Guarded	The Chao Fa know the way down to the river, and who is watching it. Their camp is watched from below. Key encounter: Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
	A Fighter's Last Word	Key · On the Fallen	A dying fighter names the crossing his family used. He fell on the path, and the soldiers who shot him are close. Key encounter: Take it now, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. An evade card, Tou or Gao can still get you away. Or leave it.



Vientiane Plain · The lowlands · 14 cards

Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. The best trade before the river, and the most soldiers. Everyone on the plain is asked for papers.

Danger 7 (hard fight) · **Forage** Spring 1, Summer 1, Fall 2, Winter 1

The lowland Lao here are not the enemy, and not all of them are friends.

	CARD	KIND	WHAT IT DOES
	Ball of Opium	Item	Money: pays a Boatman, a Price, a Trade or a shakedown. Or spend it: a Sick villager is not Sick for one Winter Toll.
	Lao Identity Card	Item	Danger 1 better when you Travel. A disguise piece: with two in the party, no one looks twice.
	Kerosene Lamp	Item	Searching: look at one card more and choose.
	The market at dawn	Food	+3 Food.
	Paddy rice and fish sauce	Food	+2 Food.
	A checkpoint on the road	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Soldiers searching a bus	Danger	Hard fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	Militia in the paddies	Danger	Medium fight now. Militia and Pathet Lao patrols to 1976; the Lao army and Vietnamese units from 1977.
	A Trail Map	Clue	Turn face up every tile in the next row.
	Too many eyes	Nothing	No effect.
	A Monk's Blessing	Escape	Keep in hand. When soldiers find you (not the River Patrol), discard it: no fight.
	A Trader's Route	Key · A Price	A market trader runs goods to the river and knows the quiet landings. He sells to anyone, including the police. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
	Papers for the Ferry	Key · A Price	A clerk sells the stamp that gets a family onto the ferry. The stamp costs more than you have. Key encounter: Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
	The Night Bus Driver	Key · Wait for Dark	A driver who takes people to the river town after dark. He only drives when the road is empty. Key encounter: Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.

EVERY CARD

Items, by where they are found

Any villager can carry any item. A villager's own item gives them the larger bonus; anyone else gets the smaller one. Legendary items work the same for everyone and each has a power. Found items have an effect printed on the card. Hmong words are in the Romanized Popular Alphabet.

Village Ruins



Soul Lock *xauv (silver neck ring)*

Chai (Senglao (Mayor)) · +2 DEF for Chai · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

A soul lock of ancestral origin.

Hmong families put a silver neck ring (xauv), often with a padlock-shaped pendant, on children and the sick to 'lock' the soul (plig) in the body and guard against illness; silver jewellery also stored family wealth. A soul-lock necklace given by Vang Pao in the 1960s is held in the CIA Museum.

Why here: Families hid silver neck rings under the floor when they fled.



Book *phau ntawv*

Tou (Teacher) · +2 DEF for Tou · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

An old self-defense book of martial arts.

Hmong was mostly an oral language until the RPA (Romanized Popular Alphabet) was devised in Laos in the early 1950s; Shong Lue Yang's Pahawh Hmong script (1959) was another. Learning to read (kawm ntawv, 'study paper') was prized, and school books and notebooks were precious in wartime villages and the camps.

Why here: The village school was abandoned with its books on the shelf.



Doll

Gao (Kid) · +2 HP for Gao · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A Hmong doll.

Children's dolls in Hmong villages were usually homemade from cloth scraps. Small dolls dressed in miniature Hmong clothing with paj ntaub trim became a common craft in the Thai refugee camps and are still made for sale.

Why here: A child's doll left on a sleeping platform.



Hammer *rauj*

Chong (Blacksmith) · +2 ATK for Chong · +1 ATK for anyone else · one hand

An iron hammer.

Hmong blacksmiths (kws ntaus hlau) forged knives, hoes and gun parts at village forges with hammer and anvil, and silversmiths hammered jewellery from melted silver coins.

Why here: The village blacksmith's forge still has its tools.



Ring *nplhaib (ring)*

Blong (Elder) · +1 HP, +1 DEF for Blong · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A very old ring with intricate carvings.

Silver rings, bracelets and neck rings were worn daily and on festival days. They were family savings as well as protection, and could be traded or sold during flight.

Why here: An heirloom ring in a wooden box under the altar.



Needles *koob (needle)*

Bao (Tailor) · +1 ATK, +1 DEF for Bao · +1 ATK for anyone else · pack

Needles used for sewing.

Needlework is central to Hmong women's craft: reverse appliqué, cross-stitch and batik for clothing and paj ntaub. Girls learned it young, and a needle and thread were packed even when fleeing.

Why here: Every house has needles and thread for paj ntaub.

Paj Ntaub *paj ntaub ('flower cloth')*

Bao (Tailor) · +1 DEF, +1 HP for Bao · +1 DEF for anyone else · body

Clothing that is used for show (flower cloth needlework).

Paj ntaub ('flower cloth') is Hmong textile art in appliqué and embroidery. In the Thai camps after 1975, women began embroidering 'story cloths' showing village life, war, and the flight across the Mekong. Note: the correct RPA spelling is 'Paj Ntaub', not 'Paj Taub'.

Why here: Flower cloth folded in a chest for the New Year.

Su-Kah *xwm kab (Dab Xwm Kab, pronounced roughly 'su-ka')*

Legendary · anyone · +1 DEF · pack

Look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

A household talisman used to protect a house.

'Su-Kah' almost certainly means Dab Xwm Kab, the household spirit of good fortune. Its altar is a sheet of white paper with gold/silver leaf squares, pasted on the main wall and renewed every New Year. It protects the home and the family's wealth, and receives offerings of incense, spirit paper, rice and chicken.

Why here: The household spirit altar on the back wall of the house.

French Silver Coins

Found item · +1 HP · pack

Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman.

Old French Indochina silver piastres, the savings of a family.

Why here: Families sewed coins into clothes or buried them under the house.

Iron Rice Pot

Found item · +1 HP · pack

The holder finds 1 extra Food each time they Forage.

A heavy iron pot for steaming rice and boiling greens.

Why here: Every hearth had one, and few families could carry it.

Village Flintlock

Found item · +2 ATK · both hands

A hunting gun: +2 ATK.

A long flintlock musket made by a Hmong blacksmith.

Why here: Hmong smiths made their own guns; one hung over many doorways.

Wood Axe

Found item · +1 ATK, +1 DEF · one hand

A tool and a weapon: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.

A narrow-bladed axe for felling and splitting.

Why here: Every house kept one by the woodpile.

Swidden Fields

Hoe *hlau (hoe*

Mai (Farmer) · +1 ATK, +1 DEF for Mai · +1 ATK for anyone else · both hands

A garden hoe.

Hmong farmers in the Lao highlands grew upland rice, corn and vegetables in hillside swidden fields, using a short-handled iron hoe (hlau) for weeding and planting on slopes too steep for plows.

Why here: Hoes were left in the field huts at the end of the season.

Knife *riam (knife)*

Mai (Farmer) · +1 DEF, +1 HP for Mai · +1 DEF for anyone else · one hand

A garden knife.

A heavy single-edged field knife was the all-purpose highland tool, used to clear brush for swidden fields, cut bamboo and build houses. Families on the run used it to cut trails and shelters.

Why here: The field knife hangs in every field hut for clearing brush.

Slingshot

Chao (Kid) · +2 ATK for Chao · +1 ATK for anyone else · one hand

A slingshot made of wood and rubber bands.

Boys in Hmong and Lao villages made forked-stick slingshots with rubber bands to hunt birds and small game and to guard crops, alongside the older crossbow.

Why here: Boys guarded the ripening corn from birds with slingshots.

Tub Luj *tuj lub (also spelled tub lub / tublub)*

Chao (Kid) · +2 DEF for Chao · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

A toy circular object that can be thrown (Hmong spinning top).

Tuj lub is a team game played especially at Hmong New Year: a heavy wooden top is wound with a cord on a stick and whipped across the ground, and players try to knock the other team's spinning top over. It is still played widely in the diaspora.

Why here: Children spun tops on the packed earth by the field huts while their parents worked.



Scythe *liag (rice sickle)*

Pao (Farmer) · +2 ATK for Pao · +1 ATK for anyone else · both hands

A garden scythe.

Upland rice was harvested by hand with a small curved sickle (liag), a word that goes back to Proto-Hmong-Mien. Harvest took the whole family.

Why here: Harvest tools stored in the granary by the field.



Carrying Basket (Kwb) *kawm (back basket*

Pao (Farmer) · +2 DEF for Pao · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

A kwb used to carry items and vegetables from the farm.

The kawm is a woven bamboo or rattan back basket carried with shoulder straps and often a forehead strap. It was used for firewood, crops, water and babies' things, and families crossing the mountains to the Mekong packed their belongings in them.

Why here: Carrying baskets are left at the field hut, ready for harvest.



Water Buffalo *twm*

Legendary · anyone · +1 DEF · shared by the party

Discard a card to gain 1 Food.

A water buffalo used to till rice fields.

Water buffalo (twm) were the most valuable livestock: wealth, plough animals and sacrifices at major funerals. Buffalo and bull fights are held at Hmong New Year in Laos.

Why here: A buffalo left in a burned field. It can be slaughtered for meat (4 Food, but -1 Hope).



Gourd Water Bottle

Found item · +1 HP · pack

Clean boiled water: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll.

A dried gourd that carries water.

Why here: Gourds grew on the field fences and carried water to the fields.



Sack of Seed Rice

Found item · shared by the party

Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

A sack of rice kept back for next year's planting.

Why here: Seed rice was stored in the field granary.



Machete

Found item · +2 ATK · one hand

A tool and a weapon: +2 ATK.

A heavy field blade for clearing brush.

Why here: Left in a field hut when the family ran.

Pine Ridge



Bow *hneev (crossbow)*

Sheng (Hunter) · +2 ATK for Sheng · +1 ATK for anyone else · both hands

A bow used to hunt pheasants and small animals.

The Hmong crossbow (hneev), one of the Austroasiatic/Southeast Asian crossbows, is a wooden hunting weapon used with bamboo bolts (xub) for birds and small game. It remains a symbol of Hmong identity and skill, and crossbow contests are held at New Year.

Why here: Hunters kept bows in their ridge-top shelters.



Hmong Gun *phom (gun)*

Sheng (Hunter) · +3 ATK for Sheng · +2 ATK for anyone else · both hands

A gun with a very long barrel, used to hunt small game.

Hmong blacksmiths made long-barrelled flintlock and percussion muzzle-loaders for hunting, firing black powder they made themselves. These guns were common in highland villages into the 1970s.

Why here: Long flintlock hunting guns were hidden in hunting shelters.



Cane *pas nrig (walking stick*

Blong (Elder) · +2 DEF for Blong · +1 DEF for anyone else · one hand

A solid wooden cane for the elderly.

Walking sticks cut from bamboo or hardwood helped elders and the injured on steep jungle trails. Many refugees walked for weeks through the mountains to reach the river.

Why here: A straight walking stick cut from the ridge forest.



Horse *nees*

Legendary · anyone · +1 HP · shared by the party

Look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

A mountain pony.

Small mountain ponies (nees) carried loads and people on Lao highland trails and were a sign of wealth. In ritual, the shaman's bench stands for the horse ridden into the spirit world, and horse fights are a New Year tradition.

Why here: A pony carries three loads and cannot enter the caves or cross the river. It can be slaughtered for meat.



Crossbow (hneev)

Found item · +2 ATK · both hands

Hunting: the holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.

A Hmong hunting crossbow with bamboo bolts.

Why here: Hunters kept crossbows in their ridge-top shelters.



Pine-Resin Torch

Found item · one hand

When the holder Searches, look at 2 cards and keep 1 (put the other on the bottom).

A bundle of pine splinters soaked in resin.

Why here: Pine pitch burns slowly; hunters lit their way with it.



Hunting Spear

Found item · +1 ATK, +1 DEF · both hands

Keeps danger at arm's length: +1 ATK, +1 DEF.

An iron spearhead bound to a bamboo shaft.

Why here: Hunters kept spears for wild pig in their ridge shelters.

Long Tieng Airstrip



Army Blanket

Found item · +1 DEF · pack

The holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll.

A heavy wool blanket from the war years.

Why here: Blankets came in supply drops to the hill airstrips.



Transistor Radio

Found item · pack

Look at the next Season card at any time.

A battery radio.

Why here: Left in the radio hut at the strip. Radios carried news of patrols and of the camps in Thailand. Once a season, look at the top Season card and put it back.



Cargo Parachute

Found item · +1 DEF · pack

A dry tent: the holder draws 1 better at the Winter Toll.

A nylon cargo parachute, white or striped.

Why here: Parachutes from rice drops lay snagged in the trees around the strips; families made tents and clothes from them.



Steel Helmet

Found item · +1 DEF · head

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF.

An American steel helmet from the war years.

Why here: Dropped with other supplies at the hill airstrips.



Flak Vest

Found item · +1 DEF · body

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. +1 DEF.

A padded vest left by an aircrew.

Why here: Abandoned in a shed when the airstrip was evacuated.

Bamboo Forest



Tsaaj Nplaim *nplooj (leaf instrument)*

Ka (Singer) · +2 HP for Ka · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

An instrument used to court people.

Hmong blow a folded leaf (nplooj), often banana, to play tones that copy spoken Hmong, so it can 'talk'. It was used for courting and, in wartime, for signals and secret messages. 'Raj nplaim' is the free-reed bamboo pipe, so 'nplooj' (leaf) is the closer match for a leaf instrument.

Why here: A leaf or bamboo-reed courting instrument made in the grove.



Bamboo Float Tubes

Found item · pack

The holder draws 2 better crossing the river.

Sealed lengths of giant bamboo tied together.

Why here: Non-swimmers tied bamboo tubes under their arms to cross the Mekong.



Bundle of Raft Poles

Found item · shared by the party

Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.

Long dry bamboo poles, cut and bundled.

Why here: Giant bamboo floats well and was lashed into rafts.



Snare Traps

Found item · pack

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.

Wire and cord snares for birds and small animals.

Why here: Hunters set snares on the rat and bird trails through the bamboo.

Phou Khao Khouay Jungle



Herbs *tshuaj ntsuab (green/herbal medicine)*

Lee (Medicine Woman) · +2 HP for Lee · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

Various herbs that smell sweet.

Hmong herbalists, often women, grow and gather plants (tshuaj ntsuab) for wounds, fevers, childbirth recovery and the special postpartum chicken soup. This knowledge is handed down in families and kept up in the diaspora.

Why here: Medicine plants grow wild in the deep forest.



Dog *dev*

Legendary · anyone · +1 HP · shared by the party

Discard a card to gain 1 Food.

A village dog used to guard a house.

Village dogs (dev) guarded homes and helped hunters. In Hmong tradition dogs also guard against spirits, and a story says a dog helped bring rice seed to people.

Why here: A village dog that ran into the forest finds you.



Rattan Rope

Found item · +1 DEF · pack

The holder draws 1 better crossing the river (tied to the raft or the others).

Rope twisted from split rattan cane.

Why here: Rattan vines grow in the deep forest.



Dropped Rifle

Found item · +3 ATK · both hands

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

A rifle left beside the trail with a few rounds.

Why here: Soldiers of the Secret Army dropped heavy gear as they fled through the forest.



Rattan Shield

Found item · +1 DEF · one hand

Armor 1 and +1 DEF.

A round shield of woven rattan, hardened over smoke.

Why here: Made in the forest from split rattan cane.

Limestone Caves



Silver Bar *nyiaj (silver/money)*

Chai (Senglao (Mayor)) · +2 HP for Chai · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A silver bar used in bartering and trade.

Hmong in Laos kept savings as silver (nyiaj): bars and old French Indochina coins, which paid bride price and were sewn or worn as jewellery. A silver bar (choj nyiaj) is still given at weddings and funerals; families fleeing in 1975-80 often carried silver as the only portable wealth.

Why here: Families hid their silver in caves before they fled.



Cloth Mask *daim phuam npog muag (face-covering cloth*

Meng (Shaman) · +1 HP, +1 DEF for Meng · +1 HP for anyone else · head

A cloth mask used to cover your face.

During a healing ceremony (ua neeb) a Hmong shaman (txiv neeb) covers the face with a black or red cloth or hood so their sight leaves the human world and they can travel among spirits to find and return a lost soul. It is a sacred object, not a costume, so depict it respectfully.

Why here: The shaman's things were carried to the caves for safekeeping.



Chu Neej *txiab neeb (rattle-ring)*

Meng (Shaman) · +2 DEF for Meng · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

A jingle set made of iron and brass.

The txiab neeb is an iron ring hung with metal jingles that the shaman shakes, along with finger bells (tswb), to start the trance and signal the journey of the shaman's 'horse' (the bench, rooj neeb). The gong (nruas neeb) and split horns (kuam) complete the main altar tools.

Why here: Shaman's rattles were hidden with other sacred things in caves.



Hmong Knife *riam (knife*

Cheng (Soldier) · +2 ATK for Cheng · +1 ATK for anyone else · one hand

A Hmong knife used in butchering animals and general use.

The everyday Hmong knife (rab riam), carried in a wooden sheath on a cord at the waist, was forged by village blacksmiths and used for cooking, carving, cutting bamboo and hunting.

Why here: Resistance fighters cached knives and tools in caves.



Medicine Box

Kong (Doctor) · +2 HP for Kong · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A medicine box.

Western medicine (tshuaj) came to Hmong areas through mission and USAID clinics and medics during the war. In the camps, families mixed clinic medicine with herbal and shamanic healing.

Why here: An aid post of the resistance kept its medicine box in a cave.



Qeej *qeej*

Ka (Singer) · +1 DEF, +1 HP for Ka · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

An instrument used to help call spirits.

The qeej is a six-pipe bamboo free-reed mouth organ whose tones 'speak' Hmong words. It is played at funerals to guide the soul of the dead back to the ancestors, and at New Year with dance.

Why here: A qeej carried up to the caves so the funeral songs would not be lost.



Incense Sticks *xyab*

Pa (Shaman) · +1 HP, +1 DEF for Pa · +1 DEF for anyone else · pack

Incense sticks used to help call spirits.

Incense (xyab) is lit at the household altar and in rituals to invite and honour spirits and ancestors, together with offerings of rice, chicken and spirit paper.

Why here: Incense left at a cave shrine.



Old Carbine

Found item · +3 ATK · both hands

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

An American carbine from the Secret Army years.

Why here: Soldiers of the resistance cached weapons in caves.



Army Poncho

Found item · +1 DEF · body

Dry in the monsoon: the holder draws 1 better at the Toll.

A rubberised rain poncho.

Why here: Left with other supplies in a resistance cave.



Hidden Rice Cache

Found item · shared by the party

Gain 4 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

Jars of rice hidden at the back of a cave.

Why here: Families stored rice in caves to hide it from soldiers.

Lao Farm Village



Translator *phau ntawv txhais lus (translation book)*

Tou (Teacher) · +2 HP for Tou · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A guide used to help translate Hmong to Lao.

Hmong and Lao are unrelated languages, and many highland Hmong spoke little Lao or Thai. Small word lists and phrase books (often RPA plus Lao or Thai) helped people get through checkpoints, the lowlands and the Thai camps, where agencies printed bilingual Hmong-Lao-Thai-English material.

Why here: Lowland traders kept Hmong-Lao word lists for doing business with hill people.



Bandages

Lee (Medicine Woman) · +1 HP, +1 DEF for Lee · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

Crudely made bandages.

Cloth strips, often torn from clothing, bound the wounds of people injured by gunfire, mines or the trek. Camp clinics later supplied proper dressings.

Why here: Cloth bought or begged from lowland villagers.



Joss Paper *ntawv txiag (spirit paper money)*

Pa (Shaman) · +2 HP for Pa · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

Joss paper used as offerings for the dead.

Spirit paper money (ntawv txiag), cut and folded from coarse paper and sometimes silver or gold leaf, is burned at funerals, soul-calling and shaman rites so spirits and ancestors receive it as money.

Why here: Spirit paper sold by lowland traders.



Rooster *qaib lab (rooster)*

Legendary · anyone · +1 ATK · shared by the party

Look at the top card of the search deck where you are.

A village rooster meant to wake people up.

Chickens are central to Hmong ritual: a rooster is used in soul-calling (hu plig) and New Year rites, chicken-skull/tongue divination reads the spirits' answer, and a rooster guides the soul of the dead at funerals.

Why here: A rooster traded or caught in a lowland village.



Lao Clothes

Found item · body

Disguise: every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.

A Lao sarong and plain shirt.

Why here: Dressing as lowland Lao helped families pass through villages and checkpoints.



Bag of Salt

Found item · +1 HP · pack

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage (salted food lasts).

Coarse salt from the lowland salt wells.

Why here: Highlanders bought salt from Lao traders; it keeps fish and meat.



Mosquito Net

Found item · pack

The holder draws 1 better at the Toll.

A cotton mosquito net.

Why here: Lowland traders sold nets; malaria killed many people in hiding.



Quinine Tablets

Found item · +1 HP · pack

The holder draws 2 better at the Toll.

A small bottle of malaria tablets.

Why here: Bought at a lowland market for silver.



Padded Cotton Jacket

Found item · body

Armor 1: stops the first damage that would go to the wearer in each fight. Warm: 1 better at the Toll.

A quilted jacket stuffed with kapok.

Why here: Lowland tailors sold padded jackets for the cold season.



Hin Heup Bridge



M-16 *phom M-16*

Cheng (Soldier) · +3 ATK for Cheng · +2 ATK for anyone else · both hands

An American-issued M-16.

During the 'Secret War' (c. 1961-1975), Hmong soldiers in Vang Pao's CIA-backed forces were issued US weapons, including the M16. After 1975 some kept these rifles to defend fleeing families and in the Chao Fa resistance.

Why here: Rifles from the Secret Army were taken at checkpoints and left in army stores.



Scalpel

Kong (Doctor) · +2 HP for Kong · +1 HP for anyone else · pack

A sharp scalpel.

Surgical tools reached the highlands mainly through wartime field hospitals such as those at Long Cheng and Sam Thong, where Hmong medics were trained.

Why here: An army medic's kit dropped by the road.



Forged Travel Pass

Found item · pack

Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better.

A stamped paper allowing travel to the river towns.

Why here: Passes were bought, forged or taken at checkpoints.



Captured Rifle

Found item · +3 ATK · both hands

A strong weapon: +3 ATK.

A rifle taken from an army store.

Why here: Army posts along the roads kept weapons and ammunition.



Army Rations

Found item · shared by the party

Gain 3 Food when found. (Then discard it.)

Tins of fish and bags of rice.

Why here: Supply trucks stopped at the checkpoint.



Army Body Armor

Found item · +1 DEF · body

Armor 2 and +1 DEF.

A heavy vest taken from an army store.

Why here: The checkpoint stores held gear for the soldiers on the road.



Nam Xan Valley



Rocks *pob zeb (stone)*

Gao (Kid) · +2 HP for Gao · +1 HP for anyone else · one hand

A small shiny rock.

Northern Laos is limestone karst. Stones were used in children's games such as 'sticks and stones' (a jacks-like game) and as weights, throwing stones and hearth stones.

Why here: Smooth bright stones from the streambed.



Sharpening Stone

Chong (Blacksmith) · +1 ATK, +1 DEF for Chong · +1 ATK for anyone else · pack

A sharpening stone used to retouch items.

Every household kept a whetstone to keep knives, sickles and hoes sharp; a good edge mattered for clearing fields and for survival in the forest.

Why here: The best whetstones are flat stones from a fast stream.



Fishing Pole

Legendary · anyone · +1 ATK · both hands

Discard a card to gain 1 Food.

A fishing pole used to catch fish.

Highland families fished streams with bamboo rods, traps and nets. At the Mekong, which many refugees could not swim, fishermen's boats and improvised bamboo floats became lifelines.

Why here: A bamboo rod left by a fisherman.



Cast Net

Found item · pack

The holder finds 2 extra Food when they Forage.

A round weighted fishing net.

Why here: Lowland fishermen leave nets drying on the rocks.



Clay Water Jar

Found item · +1 HP · pack

The holder draws 1 better at the Toll.

A jar for carrying and boiling water.

Why here: Potters worked the clay banks of the streams.



Mekong Reeds



Truck Inner Tube

Found item · pack

The holder draws 3 better crossing the river.

A patched rubber inner tube.

Why here: Inner tubes were the best floats a family could find.



Driftwood Logs

Found item · shared by the party

Lets the party build a raft without giving up 2 items.

Logs washed up on the bank.

Why here: The Mekong leaves timber on every sandbar.



Fishing Hamlet



Thai Baht Notes

Found item · pack

Pays one boat seat when you have found a Boatman.

Paper money from across the river.

Why here: Fishermen traded across the river and took baht for passage.



Bamboo Fish Trap

Found item · pack

The holder finds 1 extra Food when they Forage.

A woven cone trap for fish.

Why here: Every fishing family has a few.

Tha Deua Ferry



Dugout Canoe

Found item · shared by the party

Two people may cross by boat without paying a boatman.

A narrow dugout canoe hidden in the reeds.

Why here: The ferrymen kept small boats near the old landing.

Plain of Jars



Bomb Casing Pot

Found item · pack

+1 Food whenever the party forages.

Half a cluster-bomb casing, blackened by cooking fires

Why here: Families on the plain cooked in the halves of the bomb casings that lay everywhere.



Drop Tarpaulin

Found item · pack

The Winter Toll is 1 better for everyone.

A rotted supply-drop tarpaulin, still waterproof

Why here: Rice drops came wrapped in tarpaulin. A sheet of it keeps the rain off a shelter.



Entrenching Tool

Found item · +1 ATK, +1 DEF · one hand

+1 ATK, +1 DEF for anyone.

A folding army shovel

Why here: Dropped by a soldier on the plain. It digs a firing position or a grave.

Phou Bia Slopes



Pahawh Primer

Found item · +1 DEF · pack

+1 DEF for anyone.

A hand-copied primer in the Pahawh script

Why here: The Chao Fa taught the script of Shong Lue Yang in their camps. The book is their mark and their memory.



Field Dressing

Found item · pack

Counts as medicine for nursing. Turn it face down when used.

A sealed army field dressing

Why here: Carried by every fighter on the mountain. Counts as medicine for nursing.



Soldier's Map

Found item · pack

Searching: look at one card more and choose.

A map case with a marked sheet of the Phou Bia massif

Why here: The mountain fighters marked the paths and the hiding places. Searches here look one card deeper.

Vientiane Plain

Ball of Opium

Found item · pack

Money: pays a Boatman, a Price, a Trade or a shakedown. Or spend it: a Sick villager is not Sick for one Winter Toll.

A fist of raw opium wrapped in leaves

Why here: The cash crop of the mountains and the medicine chest of the sick. Money: it pays a Boatman, a Price or a Trade. Or spend it so a Sick villager is not Sick for one Winter Toll (it eases, it does not cure).

Lao Identity Card

Found item · pack

Danger 1 better when you Travel. A disguise piece: with two in the party, no one looks twice.

A lowland Lao identity card with a stranger's photograph

Why here: On the plain everyone is asked for papers. A card, even a stranger's, gets the party past a glance.

Kerosene Lamp

Found item · pack

Searching: look at one card more and choose.

A tin lamp with a little kerosene left

Why here: Light to search by, if you dare to show one.

EVERY CARD

The Season deck, Turning Points, strangers, dilemmas and laws

One Season card is drawn at the start of every season. When the deck runs out, shuffle the discards. 85 cards.

Patrols, food, shelter and remedies

CARD	QTY	EFFECT
Patrol: Easy	5	An easy fight wherever the party is. Win and search the place 1 time in safety.
Patrol: Medium	5	A medium fight wherever the party is. Win and search the place 2 times in safety.
Patrol: Hard	5	A hard fight wherever the party is. Win and search the place 3 times in safety.
Food +3	2	Add to the Food store now (max 20).
Food +2	3	Add to the Food store now (max 20).
Food +1	5	Add to the Food store now (max 20).
DEF +3	1	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.
DEF +2	2	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.
DEF +1	2	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.
HP +3	1	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.
HP +2	2	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.
HP +1	2	Keep in hand. Play it (1 action) to add to the next fight.

Time and history cards

A history card drawn before its year is set aside and another is drawn.

CARD	QTY	EFFECT
The Army Advances The war moves faster than you. The army takes the next valley.	5	The season is lost: move the time marker forward 1 season. In Winter, the party hides instead (as A Sweep Through the Hills).
A Sweep Through the Hills Soldiers comb the ridges. The family lies still under the leaves.	3	This season everyone has 1 action and the party cannot Travel.
A Quiet Spell The soldiers are busy elsewhere.	1	This season Travel is safe (no Danger draw) and no one is spotted while foraging.
Yellow Rain Aircraft pass low over the ridge. Refugees later told of a yellow substance falling, and of sickness and deaths after. What it was is still disputed.	1	Each person draws a Fortune card: on 4 or less they fall Sick (if already Sick, they take a wound). *From 1976.*
The Offensive on Phou Bia Lao and Vietnamese troops sweep the mountains where the resistance holds out. Villages and rice fields are burned.	1	The party loses half its Food (rounded up), and a Medium patrol finds you. *From 1977.*
A Voice on the Radio A radio voice speaking Hmong promises rice, land and forgiveness to anyone who comes down from the mountains. Some did. Many officers who went down were sent to camps and never came back.	2	Lose 1 Hope. Then, if Hope is 2 or less, the most hurt villager goes down to surrender and leaves the party. *From 1975.*
Betrayed Someone has told the soldiers where you sleep. Hmong fought on both sides of this war, and some guided the soldiers who hunted their own people.	2	A Medium patrol finds you. If you have a Guide, the Guide was the traitor: lose the Guide card, and the patrol is Hard.
Bombs in the Grass The path crosses ground bombed in the war. Small round bomblets lie in the grass and mud, and nearly one in three never went off.	2	Each person draws a Fortune card: on 2 or less they step on one and take 2 wounds.
The Burning Season Smoke from the swidden fires hangs over every valley. Nothing can be seen from far, and nothing grows in the ash.	2	This season every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 better, and no one can Forage (Spring only).
A Child Is Born A baby is born on the trail, in a shelter of leaves, and lives.	1	Hope +1. One adult goes Hungry this Winter. The baby is not a villager and cannot be lost. *From 1975.*
A Letter from America A letter, passed from hand to hand for months, from a relative already resettled. The river is the way.	1	Hope +1, and turn face up every place in the river row. *From 1976.*
The Writing of the Chao Fa A fighter shows you the script of Shong Lue Yang, the Mother of Writing, which the Chao Fa carry as their own.	1	If the party holds the Book or the Pahawh Primer: Hope +1 and one safe search here. Otherwise nothing. *From 1975.*

Ambush, fog and omens

	CARD	QTY	EFFECT
	**Ambush on the Trail** Shots from above the path. The soldiers were waiting.	3	A Medium fight: the soldiers fire first (you deal nothing in the first clash).
	**Fog in the Valley** A thick fog fills the valley for days.	2	Gain a Fog card: discard it to avoid one fight (not the River Patrol).

	Smoke on the Far Ridge A village is burning across the valley. Is it yours?	2	Keep it face up. Draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.
	Dogs Bark All Night Somewhere below, the dogs will not settle.	2	Keep it face up. Draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.
	A Spotter Plane A small plane circles twice and goes away.	2	Keep it face up. Draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.
	The Grandmother's Dream She dreamed of a river and a white horse. No one sleeps after that.	2	Keep it face up. Draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.
	Footprints That Are Not Ours Someone else walked this path in the night.	2	Keep it face up. Draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of Omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Draw one Turning Point card at random.

Turning Points

Omens stay face up. Each time one is drawn, draw a Fortune card: on 5 times the number of omens face up or less, the Turning Point comes. Shuffle the six Turning Point cards and draw one; it lasts for the rest of the game. Only one Turning Point happens in a game.

	TURNING POINT	FOR THE REST OF THE GAME
	Hunted The army has learned your family's names. Patrols carry a list.	For the rest of the game every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 worse, but every fight you win gives 1 more safe search.
	Sickness Spreads Dysentery runs through the people hiding in the hills.	Each villager draws a Fortune card: on 8 or less they fall Sick.
	Word From Thailand A message comes from a cousin in the camps: a fisherman at the hamlet will take you across.	The passage needs 1 piece fewer. A Boatman waits at the Fishing Hamlet.
	The Long Rains The rains come early and stay late. The river rises and stays high.	For the rest of the game the river is also in flood in Spring. Summer Forage finds 1 more Food everywhere.
	Someone Is Following A man has been walking behind you for two days, never closer, never gone.	The next time the party Travels, draw a Fortune card. On 10 or less he leads soldiers to you (a Hard fight). On 11 or more he is a Hmong man running too, and he joins you as a Guide.
	The Mountain Falls Spring 1978. The army takes Phou Bia, and the families who hid there come down the paths behind you.	Every square still guarded is now On the Fallen. Soldiers everywhere use the "from 1977" row. Hope +1 for the families now walking with you.

Dilemmas

There is no right answer, only a cost. The whole party decides; if you cannot agree, the oldest villager decides.

DILEMMA	CHOICE	RESULT

A Wounded Soldier A wounded man from the resistance crawls into your camp and asks to come with you.	**Take him in** Share your food. He knows where a cache is hidden, but the soldiers hunting him may follow.	−3 Food, +1 Hope, 1 safe search, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, an easy fight
	Leave him You cannot feed another mouth, and soldiers may be tracking him.	−1 Hope
A Lao Family's Granary A lowland family has a full rice granary. Your children are hungry.	**Take rice at night** Fill your baskets and hope no one wakes.	+3 Food, −1 Hope, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, an easy fight
	Ask to trade Offer something you carry. They give what they can spare.	+2 Food, give up an item
Another Family A mother and two children beg to travel with you. They have nothing.	**Welcome them** They share your fire and your rice until they find their own people.	−3 Food, +2 Hope
	Turn them away Every mouth slows the party.	−2 Hope
Fever in the Night A child is burning with fever. Your medicine is almost gone.	**Use the medicine** Give up a healing item, if you have one, to bring the fever down.	+1 Hope, give up an item, a sick or wounded person recovers
	Call the spirits and wait The shaman sits with the child through the night. The fever breaks at dawn, but the child is weak.	+1 Hope, someone takes 1 wound
An Abandoned Harvest A field of ripe rice, its owners gone. Soldiers patrol the valley by day.	**Harvest by day** Take as much as you can carry.	+4 Food, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a hard fight
	Glean at night Take only what you can find in the dark.	+2 Food
Hmong New Year It is the New Year (Noj Peb Caug). In the village there would be feasting, ball games and new clothes.	**Celebrate quietly** Cook a little extra and tell the old stories.	−2 Food, +2 Hope
	Let it pass There is no food to spare. You promise to celebrate on the other side.	no effect
Rumours of the Trail A traveller says the way ahead is watched. Someone could go ahead alone to look.	**Send a scout** The scout comes back hurt but knows the way.	someone takes 1 wound, turn up the next row
	Go on blind Trust the trail.	no effect
The March to Vientiane Spring 1975. Thousands of Hmong are walking toward Vientiane, hoping to reach the Mekong together. Ahead, at the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers wait.	**Walk with the crowd** There is safety in numbers, until the shooting starts.	+1 Hope, turn up the next row, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a hard fight
	Keep to the forest Turn back into the hills, alone.	−1 Hope

A Crying Child Soldiers are on the path below and a child will not stop crying. Many parents gave babies opium so their crying would not give the family away; some children died of it.	**Quiet the child with opium** The crying stops. The child sleeps too long and wakes weak.	someone takes 1 wound
	Hold the child and run Carry the child and break for cover before the soldiers come.	−1 Hope, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a medium fight
The Rooster Will Crow The family must move tonight. A rooster crows at dawn and a dog barks at strangers. One boy had to leave his pet rooster behind for this reason.	**Leave the animals behind** Let them go in the forest. The children cry quietly.	−1 Hope, lose your animals
	Keep them close Hold the beaks and muzzles and hope.	on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a medium fight
The Chao Fa Armed men with long hair stop you on the ridge: a Chao Fa band. They offer to let your family hide with them, but the army hunts them hardest.	**Hide with them a while** They share what they know of the forest. Then the soldiers come.	−2 Food, +1 Hope, 1 safe search, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a hard fight
	Keep to your own way Thank them and walk on alone.	no effect
Leaflets of Amnesty Planes drop leaflets: those who come down from the mountains will be forgiven. Many who went were sent to re-education camps.	**Stay hidden** Tear up the leaflets and keep going.	−1 Hope
	Argue about it all night The family is divided and no one sleeps.	+1 Food, −2 Hope
The Elder's Choice The oldest of you, hungry and slow, asks to stay behind at this place so the young can move faster.	**Stay together** No one is left. Every Danger draw is 1 worse until the next Winter.	no effect
	Let him stay He keeps a little rice and the fire. He is still in Laos. No Hope is lost, and his things pass to the party.	no effect

Strangers

Drawn with the **Seek help** action.

STRANGER	CHOICE	RESULT
A Lao Trader A trader with a pole and two baskets stops to rest. He looks at what you carry.	**Trade with him** Give up an item for rice and salt.	+4 Food, give up an item
	Let him go He might talk.	no effect
A Widow and Her Son A Hmong widow and her small son have been hiding alone since the spring (Lee clan).	**Take them with you** More mouths, but she knows the forest paths.	−3 Food, +1 Hope, turn up the next row
	Give them what you can spare A little rice and directions.	−1 Food, +1 Hope

A Deserter A young soldier from the other side, without his rifle, wants to sell what he knows.	**Pay him** He tells you where the patrols are.	give up an item, gain an escape card
	Drive him off He may go back to his unit.	on a Fortune card of 10 or less, an easy fight
A Forest Monk A Lao monk lives alone in a hut by the path. He has rice and a little medicine.	**Ask for medicine** He tends your sick.	+1 Hope, a sick or wounded person recovers
	Ask for rice He shares his bowl.	+2 Food
Hmong Hunters Two hunters from another clan are out for deer. They know these hills (Vang clan).	**Hunt with them** Share the work and the meat.	+3 Food, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, an easy fight
	Ask the way They draw the paths in the dirt.	turn up the next row
A Friendly Headman A village headman smiles, offers rice and asks where you are going.	**Tell him the truth** He may be a friend. He may not.	+2 Food, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, a medium fight
	Lie and leave at night Hungry, but unseen.	−1 Hope
A Dying Fighter An old resistance fighter, too sick to walk, says he hid things in this place.	**Stay with him to the end** He tells you where to dig.	−1 Food, −1 Hope, 2 safe searches
	Leave him your water You go on.	−1 Hope
Lost Children Three children whose parents were shot at the river are hiding in a hollow tree.	**Take them** They slow you, but how could you not?	−3 Food, +2 Hope
	Show them the way to a village Lao farmers may take them in.	−2 Hope
An Opium Smuggler A smuggler with a pack pony knows the back ways to the river, for silver.	**Hire him** Pay, and he shows a hidden path.	give up an item, turn up the next row, gain an escape card
	Keep away Smugglers attract soldiers.	no effect
A Txiv Neeb on the Trail A shaman travelling to a sick relative offers to call your souls home (Yang clan).	**Hold a ceremony** Kill your last chicken and call the souls.	−1 Food, +2 Hope, a sick or wounded person recovers
	Thank him He blesses the children as he passes.	+1 Hope
Militia at the Spring Village militia are filling their water at the spring you need.	**Wait them out** Lie still until dark.	−1 Food
	Rush them Take their water and their gear.	1 safe search, on a Fortune card of 10 or less, an easy fight

Men Around a Radio Hmong men in a clearing listen to a radio from Thailand. Names of the people in the camps are read out.	**Listen with them** You hear a cousin's name. He made it.	+2 Hope
	Ask for news of the river They tell you which crossings are watched.	+1 Hope, turn up the next row
A Lao Boatman A lowland fisherman mending nets says he has taken Hmong families across before, and asks for nothing.	**Accept his help** He will wait for you at the Fishing Hamlet.	+1 Hope
	Keep away You trust no one now.	no effect

Laws

At each Winter council, draw 2 laws the party has not adopted; the party may adopt one of them and shuffles the other back. Every law has a cost.

LAW	EFFECT AND COST
Council of Elders	The elders decide together. At every year end, +1 Hope, but 1 Food is cooked for the council.
Travel by Night	Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better, but each Forage finds 1 less Food.
Proper Funerals	Deaths cost no Hope, but each burial uses 1 Food for the funeral meal.
Everyone Nurses the Sick	Every Rest heals 1 extra wound or cures Sickness on any card, but each cure uses 1 Food for broth.
Strict Rations	In Spring and Summer only half the party (rounded up) eats. -1 Hope at every year end while anyone is hungry.
Travel Light	Each person keeps at most 3 items (discard the rest now). Every Danger draw is 2 better.

Where the harsher cards come from

Mike asked for the game to be as realistic as possible. Each of the harsher Season cards is based on a true story. **A Voice on the Radio**: the new government made leaflet drops and radio appeals in the Hmong language to bring people down from the mountains, and starving families did surrender while fighters stayed in the forest; many officers who went down were sent to seminar camps. **Betrayed**: Hmong served on both sides of the war, and many of the guards holding surrendered Hmong in 2005 were themselves Hmong. The card is a composite, not a single recorded event. **Bombs in the Grass**: over 270 million cluster bomblets were dropped on Laos and about 30% did not explode; one family fleeing in 1980 walked five days around land mines. **A Crying Child**: many parents gave babies opium to stop their crying from alerting the soldiers; some children died of it. **The Rooster Will Crow** and **The Chao Fa**: a boy whose family joined a Chao Fa band in 1977 had to leave his pet rooster behind, for fear that its crowing would reveal where they were hiding.

EVERY CARD

The River deck

21 cards, so the crossing is a story the family makes choices in rather than three blind draws. One is drawn for each person at the current check. "Better" and "worse" change that person's current check; "the drowning check" is the third check. The three monsoon cards are added only in Summer and Fall.

CARD	COPIES	WHAT HAPPENS
Slack Water For a moment the great river is almost still.	2	Current check 6 better.
The Current The Mekong pulls hard toward the south, as it always does.	3	The usual current check.
A Drifting Log A log turns slowly past in the dark.	1	**Hold on to it:** It carries you across, far downstream. You let go of everything you carry. **Let it go:** The usual current check.
The Searchlight A patrol boat sweeps its light across the water.	2	**Dive and hold your breath:** Current check 3 worse. **Lie still in the reeds:** They may see you: Fortune 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire). Then the usual current check.
The Whirlpool The water turns in a circle and pulls down.	1	**Throw a rope or float:** Spend a Rattan Rope, Bamboo Floats or an Inner Tube: you are pulled clear and cross. **Fight it alone:** The river takes you: the drowning check.
Cramp Legs lock in the cold water. A child cries out, or an old man stops swimming.	1	**Someone across swims back:** The strongest one already across goes back in: their current check 2 worse. Pass and both reach the bank; fail and both are swept away. **Float and pray:** Swept away, but floating: the drowning check 2 better.
A Sandbar Halfway across, sand under your feet. You can rest.	1	Current check 4 better.
Thai Fishermen A small boat puts out from the Thai bank to meet you.	1	They pull you aboard and you cross. Under fire they turn back: the usual current check.
The Raft Comes Apart The bamboo lashings slip loose one by one.	1	Current check 2 worse, and everyone still to cross on the raft must swim.
Cold Water The river is colder than anyone expected.	1	Current check 1 worse; 4 worse for a child, elder, sick or wounded person.
A Rain Squall Rain comes down so hard the patrol cannot see the river.	1	The usual current check, and no one else is shot going down to the water.
A Line from the Thai Bank People on the far bank have seen you and throw a rope.	1	Current check 8 better.
The Machine Gun The patrol on the Lao bank opens fire into the water.	1	**Swim under the water:** Current check 4 worse. **Swim fast on the surface:** Fortune 1–2 killed, 3–4 wounded (+4 under fire). Then the usual current check.
Flood Surge (monsoon only) A wall of brown water comes down the river.	2	Current check 5 worse.

An Uprooted Tree (monsoon only) A whole tree comes down the flood, roots and all.	1	**Hold on to the tree:** It carries you across. You let go of everything you carry. **Swim clear of it:** Current check 4 worse.
Pushed Back Thai soldiers on the far bank wave you off: the camps are full. You must land further down, in the dark.	1	Current check 4 worse.

EVERY CARD

The story cloth

Nine squares drawn for this game in the style of the story cloths stitched in the Thai camps, not copied from any real cloth. Laid out 3 × 3 inside a border of triangles, they tell the escape from the village to the camp. Read each square's story aloud when it is recovered.



1. The Village · 1961 to 1975 · Before

Houses on the slope, fields of rice and corn, a plane dropping rice

Families farmed the mountain slopes. From 1961 the men were recruited into a secret army; by 1969 it counted about 39,000, and planes dropped rice to the hill airstrips when the fields could no longer be farmed.



2. The Last Planes · May 1975 · Left behind

A plane climbing away from the airstrip, a crowd left behind

On 14 May 1975 about 2,500 officers and their families were flown out of Long Tieng. Most soldiers and their families were left at their posts and had to walk.



3. The Soldiers Come · 1975 onward · The new government

Soldiers with rifles, a burning house, families running

Many officers and officials were sent to re-education "seminars" in remote camps, where many were starved or worked to death. At the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers fired on Hmong marching toward Vientiane.



4. Into the Forest · 1975 to 1976 · Phou Bia

Families with baskets climbing toward the high mountain

Others went into the forest. Former soldiers joined the Chao Fa, and Phou Bia, the highest mountain in Laos, became their stronghold. Whole villages hid with them.



5. Hiding · 1975 to 1980 · In the jungle

A shelter under the trees, a small fire, people keeping low

Families hid in the jungle with the fighters and moved on whenever the soldiers came close. One oral history speaks of more than 100,000 people in the jungles.



6. Fire from the Sky · 1977 to 1978 · The offensives

Aircraft overhead, yellow drops falling, people running

Vietnamese regiments were sent against Phou Bia, and thousands were killed or captured. Refugees told of "yellow rain" from aircraft; what it was is still disputed.



7. The Walk South · 1975 to 1980 · The way out

A long line of families on a path winding down through the hills

Families walked for weeks toward the Mekong, carrying children and what they could. Up to a third of the Hmong of Laos left the country.



8. The Crossing · 1975 to 1992 · The Mekong

Night on the Mekong: bamboo floats and swimmers, gunfire from the Lao bank

They crossed at night on bamboo floats, rafts or hired boats, and were shot at from the Lao bank. No one counted how many drowned. UNHCR counted 211,344 people from Laos reaching Thailand from 1975 to 1979.



9. The Camp · 1975 to 1992 · Ban Vinai

Rows of long houses at Ban Vinai, a woman stitching a story cloth

Ban Vinai held 42,858 people at its peak, 90 percent of them Hmong, and families waited years for a country to take them. In the Thai camps they began to stitch story cloths like this one, so the story would not be lost.



The complete cloth: a family that recovers all nine squares reads the whole story before it crosses.

AFTER THE GAME

The two endings, and what really happened

Ending A: Across the Mekong

The survivors climb the Thai bank. Like the families who really made this crossing, they are taken to a refugee camp such as Ban Vinai or Nong Khai, and wait there for years. Say aloud the names of those who did not reach the river.

Then read *What really happened*, and finish with:

Most of those who crossed were resettled in the United States, France, Australia, Canada and French Guiana. More than 330,000 people in the United States now identify as Hmong, the largest group around Minneapolis and St. Paul.

The ones who did not cross are part of this story too. Turn the page of this ending and read what happened to them.

Ending B: The ones who stayed

Those still alive turn back into the forest around Phou Bia. They join the people later called the Chao Fa: Hmong who stayed in the jungle after 1975, moving constantly, cut off from schools, clinics and work.

Then read *What really happened*, and finish with:

A Chao Fa leader said in 2018 that if nothing is done, his people "will not die from being killed in direct confrontation, but from starvation." The Lao government denies these accounts.

Many are still there, in hiding.

What really happened

Read after either ending. The history behind the game, in date order; disputed claims say so.

1918 to 1971 · Origins: the Lord of the Sky

"Chao Fa" is a Lao title, roughly "Lord of the Sky." It was first given to Pa Chay Vue, who led the Hmong revolt against the French from 1918 to 1921, and it returned with a later movement.

In 1959 Shong Lue Yang, a Hmong farmer born in 1929 on the Vietnamese side of the border, said he had received a writing system for the Hmong in visions. His followers call him the Mother of Writing (Niam Ntawv), and his script, Pahawh Hmong, is still written today; it is part of the Unicode standard used by every computer and phone.

He was seen as a messianic figure. He fled into Laos in the early 1960s, where Vang Pao's officials saw his claims as a challenge; a French report says he was imprisoned in 1967, escaped, and built a temple on Phou Bia.

In February 1971 he was assassinated. Scholars say it was on Vang Pao's orders, but this has never been proven. His successor was killed with five disciples later that year. His followers carried his teaching on, and it became known as the Chao Fa.

1961 to 1975 · The Secret War

From 1961 the CIA recruited, armed and paid Hmong men into a secret army in northern Laos, led by Vang Pao and later called the Special Guerrilla Units. By 1969 it counted about 39,000 men. Planes dropped rice to the hill airstrips, the Lima Sites, when the fields could no longer be farmed.

Boys of 12 and 13 were recruited when the men were gone. More than 35,000 SGU soldiers were killed, most of them in northeast Laos. Many of Shong Lue Yang's followers fought in this army too.

May 1975 · Left behind

In May 1975 the communist Pathet Lao took power. On 14 May about 2,500 officers and their families were flown out of Long Tieng; Vang Pao had asked for an airlift for 5,000. Most soldiers and their families were left at their posts and had to walk.

On 29 May, Pathet Lao forces fired on Hmong marching toward Vientiane at the Hin Heup bridge. How many died has never been firmly established.

1975 to 1980 · Into the forest: the Chao Fa resistance

Some families came down from the mountains and surrendered. Many officers and officials were sent to re-education "seminars" in remote camps, where many were starved or worked to death.

Others went into the forest. In June 1975 former soldiers joined guerrilla leaders such as Zong Zoua Her, a follower of Shong Lue Yang; by 1976 Phou Bia, the highest mountain in Laos, was their main stronghold, and fighters ambushed convoys on Route 13. Whole villages hid with them: one oral history speaks of more than 100,000 people in the jungles.

In 1977 Laos signed a treaty with Vietnam, and four Vietnamese regiments were sent against Phou Bia. At least 1,300 fighters were reported killed and thousands captured; in December 1977 alone about 2,500 Hmong reached Thailand.

Refugees told of "yellow rain" falling from aircraft, and of sickness and death after. The United States called it chemical warfare in 1981; scientists later found that the samples were mostly bee droppings. What happened is still disputed.

In March 1978 the Chao Fa leader Pa Kao Her crossed to Thailand with 15 others and built bases along the border. In December 1978 a new offensive drove most groups off Phou Bia. By mid-1980 an estimated 3,500 Hmong were still fighting there.

1975 to 1992 · The river and the camps

Families walked for weeks, crossed the Mekong at night on bamboo floats, rafts or hired boats, and were shot at from the Lao bank. No one counted how many drowned.

UNHCR counted 211,344 people from Laos arriving in Thailand from 1975 to 1979. In September 1979 the Thai camps held 69,280 Hmong, 33,870 of them at Ban Vinai. Up to a third of the Hmong of Laos left the country.

Ban Vinai, opened in late 1975, held 42,858 people at its peak in 1986, 90 percent of them Hmong. Families waited there for years for a country to take them. Thailand closed it in 1992.

1980 to 2009 · The war that did not end

Pa Kao Her's group, armed for a time by China, became the Ethnic Liberation Organization of Laos and later the Chao Fa Democratic Party. When Thailand withdrew its support in 1988 the resistance shrank, but small groups stayed in the forest with their families.

In January 1997, eight Hmong civilians were killed at Muong Ouh, five of them children. In October 2002 Pa Kao Her was assassinated in Thailand; who ordered it is unknown.

In 2003 journalists reached the jungle groups and found about 2,000 to 3,000 hungry men, women and children. Two European journalists and their Hmong-American interpreter were arrested and sentenced to 15 years before being deported. The Lao government called the groups bandits and denied the rebellion existed.

In 2004 and 2005 the United States resettled about 15,000 Hmong from Wat Tham Krabok, the last wave. Hundreds came out of the forest and surrendered in 2005. On 6 April 2006 soldiers were reported to have killed at least 26 unarmed Hmong, mostly women and children, while they searched for food. The Lao government denies it.

Thousands who fled to Thailand after 2004 were held in a camp at Huai Nam Khao. In December 2009 Thailand sent about 4,500 of them back to Laos, among them 158 recognised refugees, and UN monitors were refused free access.

2010 to today · Still in hiding

After Vang Pao died in 2011, most of his supporters came out of the forest. The followers of Shong Lue Yang's teaching, led by Pa Chong Her, stayed around Phou Bia.

In October 2018 an attack on a hiding place killed five, among them a girl of 12 and a boy of 5. In 2021 an order barred civilians from the Phou Bia forest and new attacks were reported. In May 2025 three children, aged 12 to 17, were killed, and villagers were told that anyone who tried to flee would be shot.

The soldiers of the Secret War were honored late: a plaque at Arlington National Cemetery in 1997, burial in US national cemeteries from 2018, and Minnesota state veterans benefits in 2026.

AFTER THE GAME

Voices

After the ending, shuffle the Voice cards of that ending (blue for A, green for B), draw one and read it aloud. Each is built from the recollection of a real person who lived this, retold here in the game's own words, not quoted; their stories are shortened.

Ending A · Across the Mekong

Song Ly, *market seller at Long Tieng*

On 14 May 1975 she and her child boarded the last aircraft out of Long Tieng. Her husband, an air traffic controller, missed it. They found each other again within a month at the Nam Phong camp.

May Lee Soung, *nurse*

She began nursing at Sam Thong hospital at 11 and watched soldiers whose wounds were beyond treatment die in front of her. In 1975 her family went to Vientiane and hired a boat across the Mekong.

Neng "Nhia Cha" Xiong, *lieutenant, recruited at 15*

After 1975 he hid in the jungle, hunted by the soldiers. In 1979 he swam across the Mekong with his family, and lived at Ban Vinai until the camp closed.

Youa K. Vue, *survivor*

In 1979 she made a hard choice: to leave her mother and siblings behind. After days of walking her group reached the Mekong and crossed safely. On the way she met and married Xai Chou Xiong, who promised to protect her. Her mother and siblings survived in Laos.

Sao Ger Xiong, *medic*

His family hid in the jungle so he would not be imprisoned. In October 1979 he, his family and about 250 Hmong risked their lives to cross the Mekong together.

Cha Ger Moua, *boy soldier*

Two of his brothers were killed, and in 1972 he joined the army as a boy to avenge them. From 1975 his family hid in the jungle. In May 1980 he crossed the Mekong with 361 other Hmong.

Nhia Ge Vang, *captain*

After 1975 his community was moved into a village where they were ordered to learn the communist way of life. In 1979 he left for Thailand with about 1,000 Hmong.

Ending B · The ones who stayed

Xong Pao Hang, *boy soldier, recruited at 13*

His uniform had to be cut down to fit him. After 1975 his family hid. In 1978, as they fled toward Thailand, his mother and sister were shot dead by the troops pursuing them.

Xai Chou Xiong, *lieutenant*

After 1975 his family hid in the jungle. Almost all of them were killed in one attack. He survived, and reached the Thai camps in 1980.

Chong Neng Lor, *platoon commander*

Some of his soldiers were as young as 12. In 1975 he was sent to a re-education camp. He escaped from a work field into the forest and found his family in the jungle. They crossed in 1983, lived about 20 years in Thailand, and reached the United States in 2004.

Nhia Tou Pha, *lieutenant*

When the soldiers were rounded up, his family hid in the jungle. From 1975 to 1979 he fought with the Chao Fa resistance. In 1980 he fled to Ban Vinai.

Tong Chang Lee, *captain, wounded three times*

After 1975 he resisted from the jungle. He escaped to Thailand in 1979 and lived in the camps for 25 years, at Ban Vinai and then Wat Tham Krabok. He reached the United States in 2005, with the last wave.

Tong Vang, *veteran*

He came back to Long Tieng and found all the planes gone. "If you lived, you live. If you died you died."

Boua Vang Xiong, *soldier*

He kept fighting from 1973 to 1979. In May 1979 he fled to Thailand with his brother, leaving their parents behind.

AFTER THE GAME

What became of each villager

Every villager has an ending for everything that can happen to them: crossing, being still alive in Laos when the game ends, being taken prisoner, and the six ways the trail can kill. Each villager has 10 endings, 160 across the sixteen villagers, no two alike and the same on either side of the card. They are printed in the **Endings booklet** (print kit file 10), one villager after another, each ending with its number. The stories are invented, but each is built from the real accounts of families who made this journey.

Finding the number

An ending is named by the villager and a number, for example **Mai 7**. The numbers mean the same thing for every villager, so the number alone tells the fate. A death is read by its cause, the way the game told it. If the villager crossed, draw a Fortune card: 1 to 10 reads ending 1, 11 to 20 reads ending 2. The app shows the same code on its ending screen, so a game played on screen and a game played at the table read the same ending. The booklet has a family record to fill in as you play.

ENDING	WHAT BECAME OF THE VILLAGER
1	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 1–10
2	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 11–20
3	Still in Laos when the game ends · also for going down to surrender
4	Taken prisoner
5	Killed by soldiers · wounds in a fight
6	Starved
7	Died of sickness · fever, the Winter Toll, the yellow rain
8	Killed by a bomb or a mine · an old bomb, a mine
9	Drowned in the Mekong · swept away, a raft or boat lost, the current
10	Shot trying to cross · at the bank or in the water

HISTORY

Who were the Chao Fa?

The game is named after the Chao Fa, but the name meant different things to different people. This chapter explains where it came from, who it was used for, and what happened to them, year by year. It is based on true stories; where the accounts disagree, or where a claim comes from one side only, it says so.

The name

Chao Fa is a Lao phrase. *Chao* means lord and *fa* means sky, so it is usually translated "Lords of the Sky", and sometimes "god of the sky", "Prince of Heaven" or "Prince of Sky". In Hmong it is written **Cob Fab** (Hmoob Cob Fab). This is the same Lao title in Hmong spelling, and it has no separate Hmong meaning.

Why "Lords of the Sky"? The title is older than the Secret War. It had been given to Pa Chay Vue, who led the Hmong revolt against the French in 1918–1921, and Hmong hopes for a heaven-sent leader and a Hmong king run through a series of movements after him. Ian Baird writes that the name was first used in the late 1960s for the followers of one such leader, Shong Lue Yang, and that after 1975 the communist side called the Hmong fighters "Chao Fa" too. Fighters in the movement were told not to cut their hair, so that they would be protected in battle.

Where it began: Shong Lue Yang, the "Mother of Writing"

Shong Lue Yang (Soob Lwj Yaj) was born in 1929 on the Vietnamese side of the border. From 1959 he said that he received, in visions, a new writing system for the Hmong language, the **Pahawh Hmong** script. His followers call him *Niam Ntawv*, the Mother of Writing. He taught that the Hmong would have their own writing, their own king and a better future, and many people followed him.

He fled to Laos in the early 1960s, into the area held by General Vang Pao. Vang Pao's officers saw his messianic claims as a threat. Accounts say he was jailed in 1967, escaped, and built a temple near Phou Bia. In February 1971 he was shot dead at Nam Chia. His biographers say government soldiers killed him; Baird and the French asylum office write that it was on Vang Pao's orders. Who ordered it has never been proven.

His teaching outlived him. His successor Yong Lee Yang was killed later in 1971, and a woman follower, Boua Cher Yang, carried the movement on. In December 1975, before she died, she called on the followers to take up arms.

Three groups, not one

After 1975, "Chao Fa" was used for three groups of people who overlapped but were not the same:

- **Families hiding to survive.** Tens of thousands of civilians stayed in the forests, mostly not fighting, and moved, starved and died there.
- **Former soldiers who kept fighting.** Men of the CIA-backed Special Guerrilla Units, left behind when Vang Pao flew out, who took to the hills with their guns.
- **The Chao Fa movement** of Shong Lue Yang, a religious and political movement with its own leaders, beliefs and script.

Many of the movement's leaders were former soldiers, and many civilians followed them, so the lines blurred. But the movement and Vang Pao's camp were rivals, and many former officers did not share its beliefs. The Lao government and the press used "Chao Fa" for all of them. The villagers in this game are families of the first kind, caught between the other two.

The leaders

- **Zong Zoua Her** (Zoov Zuag Hawj; also spelled Xong Zoua, Tsong Zua Her). A follower of Shong Lue Yang who had recruited Hmong into Vang Pao's army, and from 1975 led the Chao Fa at Phou Bia. Accounts disagree about his rank (major or sergeant) and about his later life: some say he stayed at Phou Bia and died there around 2000; others that he went to Thailand in 1985.
- **Pa Kao Her** (Pa Kao Hê). A close disciple of Shong Lue Yang and a former soldier. He crossed the Mekong on 3 March 1978 and led the resistance from bases on the Thai border. With Chinese support his group took the name Ethnic Liberation Organization of Laos (ELOL), and later the Chao Fa Democratic Party. He was shot dead in Chiang Rai, Thailand, on 23 October 2002; who ordered it is not known.
- **Sai Shoua Yang**. A former sub-district chief who led the other main resistance group in 1976. His group was also called Chao Fa, although it kept to ordinary Hmong shaman practice. He and many of his people escaped to Thailand after the 1977 offensive.
- **Phou Bia**, the highest mountain in Laos, was the main stronghold of most Chao Fa groups.

Year by year

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
1959	Shong Lue Yang reports the revelation of the Pahawh Hmong script.
Feb 1971	Shong Lue Yang is killed. Who ordered it is alleged, not proven.
14 May 1975	Vang Pao leaves Long Tieng. A few thousand officers and families are flown out; most Hmong who sided with the Americans are left to fend for themselves.
29 May 1975	Soldiers fire on about 10,000 Hmong walking to Vientiane at the Hin Heup bridge. The reported dead and wounded vary and the true toll is not known (see "After the war").
June 1975	Former soldiers take to the hills. Paul Her, then a young SGU soldier, joins the band of Xong Zoua with 20 men.
Dec 1975	Ban Vinai camp opens in Thailand. Boua Cher Yang calls the movement to armed revolt.
1976	Resistance spreads across north-central Laos, with Phou Bia as its stronghold. Ambushes on Route 13.

1977	Families join Chao Fa bands in the jungle; in April a night attack on caves where one band is hiding kills several children. Laos and Vietnam sign a treaty (18 July). Four Vietnamese regiments are sent against Phou Bia; Lee reports at least 1,300 fighters killed. About 2,500 Hmong reach Thailand in December alone.
1977–78	Refugees describe "yellow rain" falling from aircraft, then sickness and death. This is disputed: scientists later found the samples were mostly bee droppings, and no death toll is accepted.
3 Mar 1978	Pa Kao Her crosses to Thailand with 15 others.
Dec 1978	A large new offensive on Phou Bia. Many fighters and families flee or surrender.
1979–80	China arms and trains Pa Kao Her's ELOL. Sai Shoua Yang's followers flee to Thailand. In mid-1980 about 3,500 Hmong are reported still fighting around Phou Bia. Families who had hidden for five years are still crossing: Paul Her reaches Ban Vinai on 27 May 1980, and Cha Ger Moua's family crosses that month with 361 others.
1981	The United States accuses the Soviet Union of supplying yellow rain. The charge is never proven.
1983–88	Thailand quietly allows resistance bases on its side; in 1988 it changes policy and withdraws support.
Early 1990s	ELOL becomes the Chao Fa Democratic Party. The fighting continues at a lower level.
1992	Ban Vinai and the other Hmong camps in Thailand close. Thousands are sent back to Laos during the 1990s.
c. 2000	Zong Zoua Her reportedly dies at Phou Bia.
23 Oct 2002	Pa Kao Her is killed in Chiang Rai.
2003	TIME and other reporters reach jungle groups of a few thousand ragged people, many of them children. The Lao government calls them bandits and jails two foreign journalists before expelling them.
2004–05	The United States resettles about 15,000 Hmong from Wat Tham Krabok. Hungry jungle groups begin to surrender; others cross to a camp in Phetchabun, Thailand.
April 2006	Amnesty International reports that soldiers killed at least 26 people, mostly women and children, foraging near Vang Vieng. Laos denies it.
Dec 2009	Thailand sends about 4,500 Hmong back to Laos from the Phetchabun camp, including people recognised as refugees.
2011	Vang Pao dies in the United States. Most of his supporters come out of the forests; a small Chao Fa group under Pa Chong Her stays.
Today	Small groups are still reported around Phou Bia and Xaisomboun. The Lao government denies they exist. No reliable count is known.

Numbers of fighters and people in hiding vary widely between accounts, from "less than 800" to over 17,000, and many come from advocacy groups. None is given here as fact.

Life in hiding: what survivors describe

The game's hunger, foraging, fevers and constant moving come from what people who hid in the forests later told. Groups that were still hiding in the 2000s moved camp every week or two and did not plant fields, because a field would give them away. Finding food could take 12 to 18 hours a day: cassava, wild yams, leaves and palm pith. Attacks often came while people were out foraging, and many had wounds from shrapnel. Families from the 1970s tell of sleeping in caves, creeping back at night to feed their animals, paying Lao boatmen with money sent from relatives abroad, and hearing of others who drowned or were caught at the river. Many crossed on dark nights and then spent years in Ban Vinai.

Two accounts show what joining the Chao Fa meant for a family. Zha Blong Xiong's father had been a captain in the Lao army during the Secret War and went into hiding in May 1975, because the new government wanted him for re-education. In February 1977 he came back for his family and took them to join the Chao Fa in the jungle between Luang Prabang and Vientiane. Zha Blong was ten. They left in the night, and he had to leave his pet rooster behind, because its crowing could give them away. In April 1977, while the community was hiding in caves, a night attack killed his eldest brother and several other children. For a year and eight months the family moved from one jungle to the next under attack, until they were forced to surrender, while his father and some of his men stayed in the forest. In 1980 the family fled again: five days on foot with two guides, around land mines, to a camp in Thailand, where they learned his father was alive.

Cha Ger Moua joined the SGU in 1972 as a boy soldier, about twelve years old, after losing brothers to the war. After 1975 his family hid in the jungle. In May 1980 they crossed the Mekong with 361 other Hmong.

HISTORY

After the war: Laos, 1975–1980

When Laos fell to communist forces in 1975, the Hmong who had fought beside the United States in the Secret War were left exposed. The years that followed brought persecution, fighting, hunger, disease and one of the largest escapes in Hmong history. This is the world of the game. Each event below says where it appears in play.

1. The fall of Long Tieng, May 1975

Long Tieng (Long Cheng) was the headquarters of General Vang Pao and the CIA-backed Hmong forces. Between about 12 and 14 May 1975, some 2,500 officers and their families were flown to Thailand; Vang Pao left on 14 May. Tens of thousands were left behind, and many set out on foot for the Mekong. *In the game: the start. Your village has been left behind.*

2. The Hin Heup bridge, 29 May 1975

About 10,000 Hmong walking toward Vientiane were fired on by soldiers near the Hin Heup bridge. Reports of the dead range from about a dozen to more than twenty, with over a hundred wounded; the true toll is not known. (Some accounts give 28 May; most give 29 May.) *In the game: the dilemma The March to Vientiane, which can only come up in the spring or summer of 1975.*

3. The campaigns against the resistance, 1975–1980

Lao government forces, backed by Vietnamese troops, attacked the Hmong who held out in the mountains, above all around Phou Bia. In 1977 four Vietnamese regiments were sent there; at least 1,300 fighters were reported killed and thousands captured. Villages, rice fields and food stores were destroyed, and civilians suffered alongside the fighters. *In the game: patrols, the Season card The Offensive on Phou Bia (from 1977), and the ending for those who stay.*

4. Yellow Rain, late 1970s

Refugees reported aircraft releasing a yellow substance over villages, followed by illness, bleeding, breathing problems and deaths. In 1981–82 the United States accused the Soviet Union, Laos and Vietnam of toxin warfare. Scientists later found that the yellow samples were mostly the droppings of wild honeybees. What happened is still disputed, and there is no accepted death toll. *In the game: the Season card Yellow Rain (from 1976). It makes people sick and does not say what it was.*

5. The Mekong, 1975–1980

Tens of thousands crossed the forests and mountains to the Mekong and swam, floated or paid their way across, often at night, on bamboo floats, small boats or rafts. They faced drowning, gunfire from the Lao bank, hunger, sickness and exhaustion, and families were separated. Some who reached Thailand were sent back. *In the game: the River Patrol and the three crossing checks.*

6. Re-education camps, from 1975

Officials, soldiers and others tied to the old government were sent to re-education camps for forced labor, on little food, often for years; some died there. Published estimates of how many people from all of Laos were held run from 30,000 to 50,000; there are no official figures, and no reliable count for the Hmong. *In the game: the dilemma Leaflets of Amnesty, and the stories of those who stay.*

7. Starvation, disease and displacement

Families driven from their villages and fields lived in the mountains without dependable food, medicine or shelter. Malnutrition, malaria, other diseases and exposure killed many, mostly in places where no one recorded the deaths. *In the game: Food, the Winter Toll, fever and the sick.*

8. Ban Vinai and the camps

Ban Vinai opened in December 1975 and became the largest Hmong camp in Thailand. Families arrived having lost relatives, homes, land and everything they carried. The camp was crowded, short of medicine and uncertain about the future; at its peak in the 1980s it held more than 40,000 people. It closed at the end of 1992, and most of its people were resettled in the United States, France, Australia, Canada and French Guiana. *In the game: the ending for those who cross.*

Crossing the Mekong: what was counted, and what was not

WHAT	FIGURE
People from Laos arriving in Thailand, 1975–1979 (lowland Lao and highlanders together)	211,344
Laotian refugees in Thailand by December 1975, "all but 10,000" of them Hmong	54,000
Hmong in Thai camps on 30 September 1979 (33,870 at Ban Vinai)	69,280
Arrivals from Laos per month in 1979, before and after the Thai–Lao agreement of August 1979	about 6,000, then about 3,000
People who drowned or were shot crossing the Mekong	not known

How many died?

Estimates of Hmong deaths after 1975 run from about 50,000 to 100,000. The best-known range comes from W. Courtland Robinson's *Terms of Refuge* (1998); it covers fighting, disease and starvation from 1975 into the following decades, not only 1975–1980 and not only the river. The Hmong population of Laos before the exodus was never counted: estimates run from about 300,000 to 350,000, the figure in the designer's notes.

For many families, the end of the Vietnam War was not the end of the violence. It was the start of another time of survival, separation and displacement. Much of it was never written down, and lives on in the memories of those who lived through it.

HISTORY

The Special Guerrilla Units, remembered

Many of the families who fled were the families of the Special Guerrilla Units (SGU), the army the CIA raised among the Hmong and other peoples of Laos from 1961 to 1975. SGU Veterans and Families of USA puts the dead at about 35,000 soldiers; other counts run from 10,000 to over 40,000. By 1971 the average soldier was 15, and boys of 10 to 13 were recruited. They cut North Vietnamese supply lines, guarded American radar sites and rescued downed American pilots, sometimes 100 to 200 soldiers risking their lives for one pilot. After 1975 most of them were left behind.

WHERE	RECOGNITION
United States	Laos Memorial plaque at Arlington National Cemetery (May 1997); Hmong Veterans' Naturalization Act (2000); Hmong Veterans' Service Recognition Act (March 2018): burial in national cemeteries
Minnesota	May 14 is Hmong SGU Remembrance Day, the day of the last flights from Long Cheng; state veterans benefits passed in 2026 (enrollment from 1 July 2026)
Wisconsin	Veteran mark on licenses and IDs (2024); military funeral honors (2026); memorials in Wausau (2016) and other cities
California	Resolutions honoring SGU veterans; the Secret War taught in schools; Fresno memorial (2005): two Hmong soldiers rescuing a wounded American pilot
Connecticut	First state to give burial rights in a state veterans cemetery (2019)
Alaska, Oklahoma, Michigan, North Carolina, Colorado	Recognition days and resolutions: May 15 in Alaska and Oklahoma, May 14 in Michigan, July 22 first marked in Golden, Colorado (1995)

HISTORY

Lao neighbours who helped

The game's Lao villages, the ferry and the Vientiane plain are not enemy ground. Lowland Lao farmers hid Hmong families in their rice barns, fed them, sold them boat seats at a fair price and sometimes rowed them across for nothing; others informed on them for a reward, or sold them to the militia. The Strangers deck holds both: the trader, the friendly headman, the boatman and the forest monk on one side, the militia at the spring and the informer on the other.

The Friendly Headman and the Lao Boatman cards are the game's way of saying that the crossing was almost always made with Lao help. A family that reached the river had usually been passed from one lowland house to the next, by night, by people who took a great risk to do it. The Companion says this plainly because the cards cannot: the enemy in Chao Fa is the army and the state that sent it, not the Lao.

HISTORY

Women on the trail

Half of the villagers in the game are women, and that is not a courtesy. On the trail the women carried the children, the rice and the cooking pots, kept the fire small, found the greens and the roots that fed a family when the rice was gone, nursed the sick with herbs, and stitched the story cloths in the camps that are the reason the world knows this story at all. The game gives Mai the fields and the hoe, Sheng the crossbow of a hunter, Pa the bones and the spirits, Ka the songs, and Lee the medicine, because those are things women did.

The accounts of the flight that survive are often women's: the mother who crossed the river with a child tied to her back and a bamboo float under her arm, the widow who led her family after the men were taken, the grandmother who knew which leaves to boil. When a woman in your party is the last one standing, that is history, not an accident of the cards.

CREDITS

About this book

Chao Fa is based on true stories. The villagers are invented; the history, the endings, the Voices and the harsher cards are drawn from the accounts of Hmong families who lived through the years after 1975 and from the records of that time. Disputed figures say that they are disputed.

All icons, scenes, portraits and story cloth squares in this book and in the game are original artwork drawn for Chao Fa.